



CITY RELOCATION GUIDE · AUSTRALIA

Adelaide

Where you would work, where you would live, and what an ordinary week looks like in Adelaide.

Ethicare Resourcing

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ethicareresourcing.com

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This guide is free, and so is everything in it. Every chapter here is also on the website, where it is kept up to date — so if you are reading this some months after downloading it, check the site for anything that looks time-sensitive. Fees, tax rates and immigration settings change without much notice.

We don't print these. A PDF costs nothing to send and nothing to ship, which felt like the right answer for a company that spends its days moving people around the world.

Welcome to Adelaide

Adelaide Guide · Chapter 1 of 9

Adelaide is the Australian city where the arithmetic still works: a genuine tertiary career, a house you can actually buy, the hills twenty minutes from the wards and the sea forty. It asks one thing in return — that you like your city elegant and unhurried rather than enormous.

A capital built on a plan

Around 1.4 million people live on a grid Colonel Light laid out in 1836, ringed completely by parklands — a piece of city planning so unusual that it still shapes daily life here. The Torrens runs through the middle, the Adelaide Hills rise behind, and the gulf beaches run thirty-odd kilometres down the western edge with a tram to the middle of them.

For clinicians the draw is a health system that is genuinely large for the city's size, anchored by one of the newest hospital-and-research precincts in the southern hemisphere along the city's western boulevard. It is a system you can know personally within a year — which cuts both ways, and this guide is honest about that.

The honest costs are a fierce, dry summer with real 40-degree runs, power bills among the dearest in the country, and a job market that is one city deep. What you get back is time: the shortest commutes of any mainland capital, and a weekend that starts twenty minutes from your front door.

Who wrote this

We're a healthcare recruitment company, so we have an interest — but this guide isn't a pitch. There's nothing in it asking you to register, no form, and no visa advice.

Adelaide is where the money and the life line up best of the mainland capitals, and also where "will the job market fit me?" needs the most honest answer. Where we think it's the wrong city for you, we say so.

The city, in nine numbers

~1.4M

People in Greater Adelaide — roughly three in four South Australians live in or around the capital.

20 min

From the city to the Adelaide Hills. The sea is about forty. This is the “twenty-minute city” people talk about.

~30 km

Of white-sand metropolitan beach, from North Haven down to Sellicks — with a tram to the middle of it.

1836

Founded as a planned free settlement — no convicts, a fact locals will mention — on a grid inside a complete ring of parkland.

~50%

Of Australia’s wine is made in this state, and the Barossa, Clare, McLaren Vale and the Hills all sit within about an hour.

3

Metropolitan health networks — central, northern and southern — plus a statewide women’s and children’s service.

UTC+9½

The half-hour time zone — thirty minutes behind Sydney and Melbourne, with daylight saving in summer.

March

The Fringe, the Festival, WOMADelaide and the motorsport all at once. Locals call it Mad March, and mean it.

10c

Per can and bottle — the container deposit has run since 1977, and returning them is a genuine local habit.



North Terrace — galleries and museums a short walk from the city centre

Six things you only learn once you're here

The half-hour clock is real

Thirty minutes behind the east coast. National meetings land at odd times, football starts at half past, and every newcomer misses one call in their first month.

Summer is dry and serious

Heatwaves run past 40° for days, then break with a cool change off the Southern Ocean you can feel arrive. A good split system is infrastructure, not comfort.

Power bills bite

South Australian electricity is among the dearest in the country. An efficient home and a carefully chosen energy plan matter more here than almost anywhere.

It's a two-degrees city

"Which school did you go to?" is a genuine Adelaide icebreaker. Everyone seems to know everyone — which makes reputations, good and bad, travel fast.

The deli is an institution

The corner deli — part milk bar, part grocer — survives here as it does nowhere else, along with Foodland, the fiercely local supermarket.

Nothing is far

Most of Adelaide is twenty-odd minutes from most of the rest of it, with no toll roads anywhere. It resets what you think a commute costs you.

A note on Country

Adelaide stands on Kurna Country — Tarntanya, the place of the red kangaroo — and the Adelaide Plains carry Kurna names you will see in dual naming across the parklands, the city squares and health services. Acknowledgement of Country opens meetings, and health services work in partnership with Aboriginal community-controlled organisations. Take the cultural induction seriously.

How to read this guide

Nine chapters, all about Adelaide specifically. Topics true across the state — the Riverland, the Eyre Peninsula, the South-East and the country health networks — sit in the [South Australia guide](#). Anything true of Australia generally — Medicare, visas, Ahpra registration, tax, superannuation, schools — lives once in [Moving to Australia](#).

If you read nothing else, read [Why Adelaide](#) for the full case — and what we'd ask you to weigh, and [Where clinicians live](#), because Adelaide's villages are a enjoyable decision rather than a stressful one.

Why Adelaide

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Every city has a brochure. This chapter is the conversation we'd have instead: what Adelaide actually gives a working clinician, the arithmetic that works, what a week here plausibly looks like — and who we'd honestly point to a bigger city.

The arithmetic

Start with the sum most people never quite write down. Adelaide is the most affordable mainland capital: a three-bedroom family house rents for hundreds of dollars a week less than its Sydney equivalent, and buying one is a realistic mid-career plan rather than a fantasy. There are no toll roads anywhere in the state, commutes are among the shortest of any Australian capital, and — unlike Sydney, Melbourne, Brisbane or Perth's eastern equivalents — the whole of South Australia is classed as regional for skilled migration, which can mean extra visa points and pathways.

Against that, salaries sit broadly in the national range for public health — the enterprise agreements differ state by state, and we'll always walk you through the current ones rather than quote figures here. The point isn't that you earn dramatically more in Adelaide. It's that the same career buys noticeably more life.

\$0

Toll roads in the state

<1 hr

To the Barossa, the Vale or the Hills

100%

Of SA counts as regional for migration

A typical week

A week here can plausibly hold all of this. A city-hospital shift that starts without a toll-road crawl, because most of Adelaide is twenty-odd minutes from most of the rest of it. A swim at Henley or Brighton before a late start — the sea sits at the end of the tram line. A Thursday-evening shop at the Central Market, where the produce is better and cheaper than any supermarket. Saturday lunch at a McLaren Vale cellar door, forty minutes south, and Sunday on the Heysen Trail in the Hills before the working week resets.

None of that is a holiday itinerary. It's the ordinary shape of a week when a city this liveable is also this small — and it is exactly what people mean when they say their salary “goes further” here. The distance between your roster and your life shrinks.

Sophie's insight

What I love most about Adelaide is how much life it offers for the money. Having spent years in the NHS, I know how easily work can take over — and what stands out here is how close everything is. The hills, the sea and the vines are all a short drive away, and people genuinely make time for them.

My advice: think about your commute, your community and what you'll do on your days off. Those things shape your happiness more than people expect.

Sophie Careem Founder & CEO, Ethicare Resourcing

When we'd point you to a bigger city

The market is one city deep

Adelaide carries fewer tertiary sites than Sydney, Melbourne or Brisbane, so a narrow sub-specialty may simply have more room on the east coast. Ask us early if that describes you.

Summer is fierce

Dry heat, real 40-degree runs, and a long brown February. If you wilt in heat and can't love an early-morning life for two months a year, think hard.

It's a quiet city

Adelaide is elegant, not electric. If what recharges you is big-city churn — new restaurants weekly, a giant professional scene — Melbourne or Sydney will fit better.

The east coast is a flight away

Melbourne is eight hours' drive, Sydney fourteen. If your family network lands in the eastern capitals, every visit becomes a fare rather than a drive.

Everyone knows everyone

A small professional community is warm and quick to include you — and unforgiving of a bad first impression. Reputations travel faster here than in a big system.

Where we'd steer you instead

If you need system scale and sub-specialty depth, [Melbourne](#) or [Sydney](#) carry more sites.

If winter sun is the whole point, [Brisbane](#) is the honest answer — Adelaide winters are cool and green.

If it's the country posts and the incentives that interest you, the [South Australia guide](#) covers the Riverland, the gulfs and the South-East properly.

In our experience

Adelaide suits clinicians who are done trading hours for postcode — the twenty-minute commute is real, and it compounds into something bigger than it sounds. The people who thrive here measure a city by their weekday evenings, not its skyline.

Adelaide at a glance

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Before the practical chapters, orientation. Adelaide is the easiest Australian capital to read: a planned grid in the middle, parklands all the way around it, the hills on one side and the gulf on the other, and almost nothing more than half an hour away.

How the city is laid out

The grid and the parklands

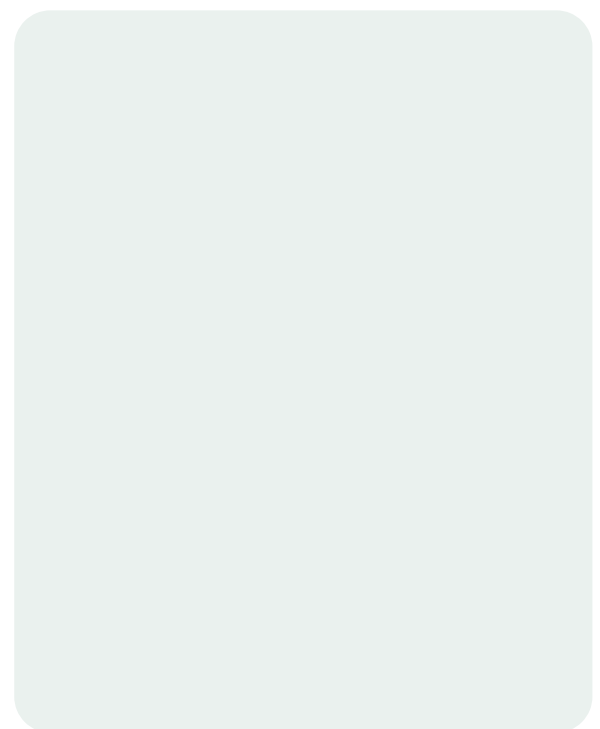
The city centre is a mile-square grid of wide streets and five public squares, wrapped completely by parkland — there is no continuous built edge between the city and North Adelaide. The Torrens runs through that green belt, with the cultural boulevard of North Terrace along the northern edge carrying the museum, the gallery, the university and the newest hospital-and-research precinct.

The coast

Thirty-odd kilometres of white sand run down the western edge, from North Haven through Henley, Glenelg and Brighton to Seacliff and, further south, Sellicks. Glenelg has the tram; the rest have jetties, esplanades and gulf sunsets. The beach suburbs are twenty to thirty minutes from the city and priced accordingly.

The hills and the valleys

Behind the city the Adelaide Hills rise within twenty minutes — cooler, greener, with autumn colour and Sunday-morning fog. Beyond them the wine valleys wrap the capital: the Barossa and Clare to the north, McLaren Vale and the Fleurieu to the south, all inside an hour.



Where Adelaide sits, with the straight-line distance to Barossa and Victor Harbor

A Mediterranean year

Hot, dry summers and mild, green winters, with the rain arriving May to September. Summer brings real heatwaves – runs of days past 40° most years – which end, theatrically, with a cool change rolling in off the Southern Ocean that can drop the temperature ten degrees in minutes. The Hills sit several degrees cooler; the coast gets the sea breeze first.



Summer
Dec – Feb
17–29°
Dry heat · 40° runs
Autumn
Mar – May
12–23°
Mad March · vintage
Winter
Jun – Aug
8–16°
Cool, green, wet
Spring
Sep – Nov
11–22°
Jacarandas · festivals

Two practical notes. Older housing stock often has thin insulation and patchy heating – make a good split system a rental-search criterion, for both ends of the year. And take the heat itself seriously: hydration, sun protection and a plan for very hot days matter, especially with children or older family members.

The half-hour clock

South Australia runs on Australian Central Standard Time – UTC+9½, thirty minutes behind Sydney and Melbourne – and, unlike Queensland, it does observe daylight saving. The practical effects are small but constant: national meetings land at five past the half-hour, broadcast times shift, and Perth sits ninety minutes behind you in winter. You adjust within a month; your phone adjusts instantly.

Getting in and out

Adelaide Airport is unusually close to the city – about fifteen minutes from the CBD, on the way to the beach. It flies direct to every Australian capital and to a handful of international hubs, so most of the world is one stop away. Melbourne is a day's drive or a short flight; everywhere else east is realistically a flight. The [South Australia guide](#) covers the drives out to the regions.

Words you'll hear in week one

TarntanyaKurna name for the Adelaide Plains – “place of the red kangaroo”; widely used in dual naming
Mad MarchThe month the Fringe, Festival, WOMAAdelaide and the motorsport all happen at once

The cool changeThe southerly front that ends a heatwave — you can feel the temperature drop in minutes
Stobie poleSA's concrete-and-steel power pole, invented here because termites eat wooden ones
FritzThe luncheon sausage every SA childhood runs on — ask for it at the deli, on white bread with sauce
Heaps goodHigh praise, delivered flat. The state's unofficial motto
The ParadeNorwood's main street — one of the city's village high streets
Pie floaterA meat pie upturned in pea soup — a heritage-listed Adelaide late-night institution

Healthcare in Adelaide

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Registration is national; hiring here runs through three metropolitan networks. Adelaide's distinguishing feature is a health system that is genuinely large for the city's size, anchored by one of the newest hospital-and-research precincts in the southern hemisphere — and small enough that you will know it within a year.

How the metropolitan system is organised

South Australia runs its public system through ten local health networks. Three of them cover metropolitan Adelaide — broadly the central city, the northern suburbs and the south — and a fourth is a statewide women's and children's service based in the capital. Each network employs in its own right, so moving between them later is a fresh application rather than a transfer.

Alongside them sit a substantial private and not-for-profit hospital sector concentrated in Adelaide, a state ambulance service, university-linked research institutes clustered along the city's northern boulevard, and Aboriginal community-controlled health organisations.

A new precinct

The city's western boulevard now holds one of the newest hospital-and-research precincts in the southern hemisphere — hospital, medical research institutes and university health faculties on adjacent sites.

Three metro networks

Central, northern and southern Adelaide, each anchored by a major teaching hospital. The north is the growth corridor, where demand has risen fastest.

A statewide children's service

Paediatric and maternity specialist care runs as its own network from Adelaide, serving the whole state with outreach into the regions.

One national register

Ahpra registration works everywhere in Australia. The process, English evidence and assessment live once in [Eligibility & registration](#).

“A job in Adelaide” is a job with one of these. Each hires in its own right, so which one you apply to also decides your campus, your case mix and your commute.

Central Adelaide	The new precinct on the city’s western boulevard – hospital, medical research institutes and university health faculties on adjacent sites, with the state’s major trauma capacity. The deepest research links in the state sit here.
Northern Adelaide	The growth corridor. Demand has risen fastest here and recruitment follows it, which makes this the most consistently open door for clinicians arriving from overseas.
Southern Adelaide	Its own teaching hospital with a network of community and specialist sites around it, on the coastal side of the city – and the shortest commute for anyone drawn to the southern beaches.
The statewide children’s service	Paediatric and maternity specialist care runs as its own employer from Adelaide, serving the whole state with outreach into the regions. A whole career in children’s work is possible without changing employers.

Moving between them later is a fresh application rather than a transfer, so it pays to choose deliberately the first time. Registration itself is national and portable: [Eligibility & registration](#).

What that means for a career

Adelaide gives you tertiary and quaternary medicine – including the state’s major trauma capacity and its teaching, research and specialist services – in a city where you can live twenty minutes from work. That combination is rare, and it is the honest reason clinicians move here.

The trade is depth of market. There are fewer tertiary sites than Sydney, Melbourne or Brisbane, so a very narrow sub-specialty may have one or two possible employers in the whole city. Ask us early if that describes you – we would rather tell you before you apply than after. In exchange, a smaller system means you are known by name quickly, and opportunities travel through relationships faster than through advertisements.

One structural advantage worth repeating: the whole of South Australia – Adelaide included – is classed as regional for skilled migration, which can open extra visa pathways and points that the eastern capitals cannot. For internationally trained clinicians that is concrete, and it is why Adelaide is often the shortest route into Australia. The detail lives in [Visas & the move](#).

“

Tertiary medicine, a twenty-minute commute, and a capital that counts as regional for migration.
The one-line version

What to ask at interview

Pay here follows state enterprise agreements that differ from the east coast's – we deliberately quote no figures in this guide, and will always walk you through the current agreement for your profession instead.
What you can pin down at interview:

Salary packaging – public-health roles can package part of your pay pre-tax; ask how much and how to start it on day one

Which network and which campus, and whether you may be rostered across sites

The roster reality – shift patterns, penalties, on-call frequency and how rosters are actually built

Public, private or both – many Adelaide careers mix the two; ask what rights of private practice exist

CPD – funded time and money, and whether interstate conference travel counts

Supervision and support – especially for internationally trained clinicians in your first year

Research links, if that matters to you – the precinct makes joint appointments more possible than the city's size suggests

Professional indemnity – what the employer covers and what remains yours to hold

Two things to do early

Start registration as soon as Adelaide is on your shortlist – paperwork, not ambition, is what moves start dates. And once you land, arrange ambulance cover: it is not automatic in South Australia, and a state ambulance membership or insurance add-on is inexpensive insurance against a very expensive ride.

Where clinicians live

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Adelaide is small enough that this decision is forgiving – get it slightly wrong and you’re still twenty minutes from work. That makes it one of the more enjoyable housing decisions in Australia rather than a stressful one. Here is the map as we’d draw it over coffee.

ON THE MAP

— THE INNER RING

- | | |
|------------------|------------|
| 1 North Adelaide | 2 Prospect |
| 3 Unley | 4 Norwood |
| 5 Goodwood | |

— THE COAST BY TRAM

- | | |
|------------|------------|
| 6 Glenelg | 7 Brighton |
| 8 Somerton | 9 Henley |
| 10 Grange | |

— THE HILLS & NEAR VALLEYS

- | | |
|-------------|-----------------|
| 11 Stirling | 12 Aldgate |
| 13 Crafers | 14 Mount Barker |

— THE CORRIDORS

- | | |
|-----------------|------------|
| 15 Mawson Lakes | 16 Gawler |
| 17 Seaford | 18 Aldinga |

● Parks & nature ● Beaches ● Landmarks

Shaded areas are the suburbs named in this chapter. Arrows point to places beyond the map edge, with the straight-line distance from the city centre.

The inner ring

North Adelaide, Prospect, Unley, Norwood, Goodwood: bluestone villas and cottages on tree-lined streets, cafés on the corner, the parklands between you and the wards. This is where many hospital staff start — walkable, characterful, close to everything — and where rents run highest, though “highest” here would read as ordinary in Sydney. Apartments in the CBD itself suit short first leases while you learn the city.

The coast by tram

Glenelg, and the beach suburbs running north through Brighton, Somerton, Henley and Grange, give Adelaide something rare among capitals: sand at the end of a tram line, with city hospitals a straightforward ride away. Sunsets over the gulf, esplanade coffee, jetty swims before a late shift. Summer weekends get busy and parking with them; that is the whole complaint.

The Hills and the near valleys

Stirling, Aldgate and Crafers sit in genuine hill country — cooler, greener, autumn colour, a Sunday-morning fog — twenty to thirty minutes up the freeway from town. Further out, Mount Barker is one of the fastest-growing towns in the state and noticeably better value. The trade: you will drive, and on summer fire-danger days you'll live by the warnings like everyone else.

The corridors, north and south

Adelaide's growth is happening in two directions. North through Mawson Lakes and toward Gawler, and south through Seaford and Aldinga toward the Fleurieu: newer housing, bigger blocks, the most affordable family homes in the metropolitan area, and their own hospital campuses in both directions. Both corridors are rail-served, which matters more here than the distance does — the northern network is where health demand has grown fastest.

The honest comparison

~A\$560/wk

Indicative Adelaide house rent (3-bed median)

~20 min

A normal commute, almost anywhere to anywhere

4 wks

Maximum bond, plus up to two weeks' rent in advance

If you want...	Consider	Because
Walk or ride to the campuses	North Adelaide, Prospect, Unley	Bluestone villages across the parklands
Beach life on a roster	Glenelg to Grange	The tram and the coast road do the commute
Village high streets	Norwood, Goodwood	Cafés, schools, ten minutes from town
Space and a garden	Mount Barker & the Hills	Value, schools, freeway access – bring a car
A new family house	The northern & southern corridors	Newest housing, own hospitals, rail-served
Vines out the window	The Fleurieu & near Barossa towns	Village life, the city under an hour away

Renting itself – applications, bonds, rights, the documents that win a tight market – works the same across Australia and lives once in [Living in Australia](#). The one Adelaide habit worth copying: arrive with your references, proof of income and offer letter as clean PDFs; a complete same-day application regularly beats a longer local history.

Before you sign a lease

Is the property inside the school zone you need? Zones run street by street here.

Does the home have decent cooling and heating? Older stock often doesn't, and the bills follow.

How long is the commute at your actual shift times – and is there parking at both ends?

Would a short-term rental first be wiser? Most people re-choose their suburb once they know the city.

Getting around

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Adelaide's transport story is mostly the absence of pain: no toll roads anywhere in the state, some of the shortest commutes of any Australian capital, and an airport fifteen minutes from the office. This is the chapter where the city quietly wins.

The network, in four parts

metroCARD

Trains, trams and buses run on one tap-on card — or just a contactless bank card. Simple, and cheap by east-coast standards.

The tram

One line, but the right one: free through the city centre, then out to the beach at Glenelg. It makes the coast a commute, not an outing.

Trains

Suburban lines reach the coast, the northern growth corridor and the south. Small network, honest timetable, useful if you live on one.

The O-Bahn

Adelaide's oddity: buses on a guided concrete track to the north-east — one of the fastest suburban runs in the country.

Living car-free is realistic along the tram corridor, in the inner ring and near a train line. It stops being realistic in the Hills and the outer corridors — plan on a car for those from day one.

Driving here

Australians drive on the left, and Adelaide is the easiest capital to learn in: a flat grid, ring routes, no tolls, and rush hours that would make a Sydneysider laugh. You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for a period after arriving, then transfer to a South Australian licence once you're resident — the rules, and buying a car, live in [Living in Australia](#).

Two local notes. The power poles are concrete-and-steel stobie poles — unforgiving, which is partly why Adelaide drivers treat them with respect. And once you leave the metropolitan area the distances lengthen fast: fuel stops you plan rather than assume, and wildlife at dawn and dusk.

Distances that actually matter

From the CBD to...	Roughly	How
The inner ring (Norwood, Unley, Prospect)	5–12 min	Drive, bus or bike
Glenelg and the coast	~25 min	Tram
Adelaide Airport	~15 min	Drive or bus
The Adelaide Hills (Stirling)	~20 min	Drive
Mount Barker	~35 min	Drive
McLaren Vale	~40 min	Drive
The Barossa	~1 hr	Drive
Melbourne	~8 hrs	Drive, or hourly flights

The takeaway

In Adelaide, transport will be the least of your problems — pick a home near your work or a tram or train line and the city does the rest. The hours this gives back are the least-discussed and most-felt advantage of living here.

Cost of living

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The honest picture is a happy one, so let's audit it anyway. Adelaide is the most affordable mainland capital, and there are three costs the sunshine hides that deserve to be weighed before you commit.

Why there are no prices on this page

We used to print a weekly rent and a monthly budget table here. We have taken them out. A figure that was true when a page was written is misleading a year later, and a candidate who plans a move around a stale number is worse off than one who plans around none.

What does not go stale is the *shape* of a month, and the judgement about which lines will surprise you — which is what the rest of this chapter is for. For today's actual numbers use the calculators at the foot of the page, and use them to compare Adelaide against the city you are leaving. That is the only comparison that decides anything.

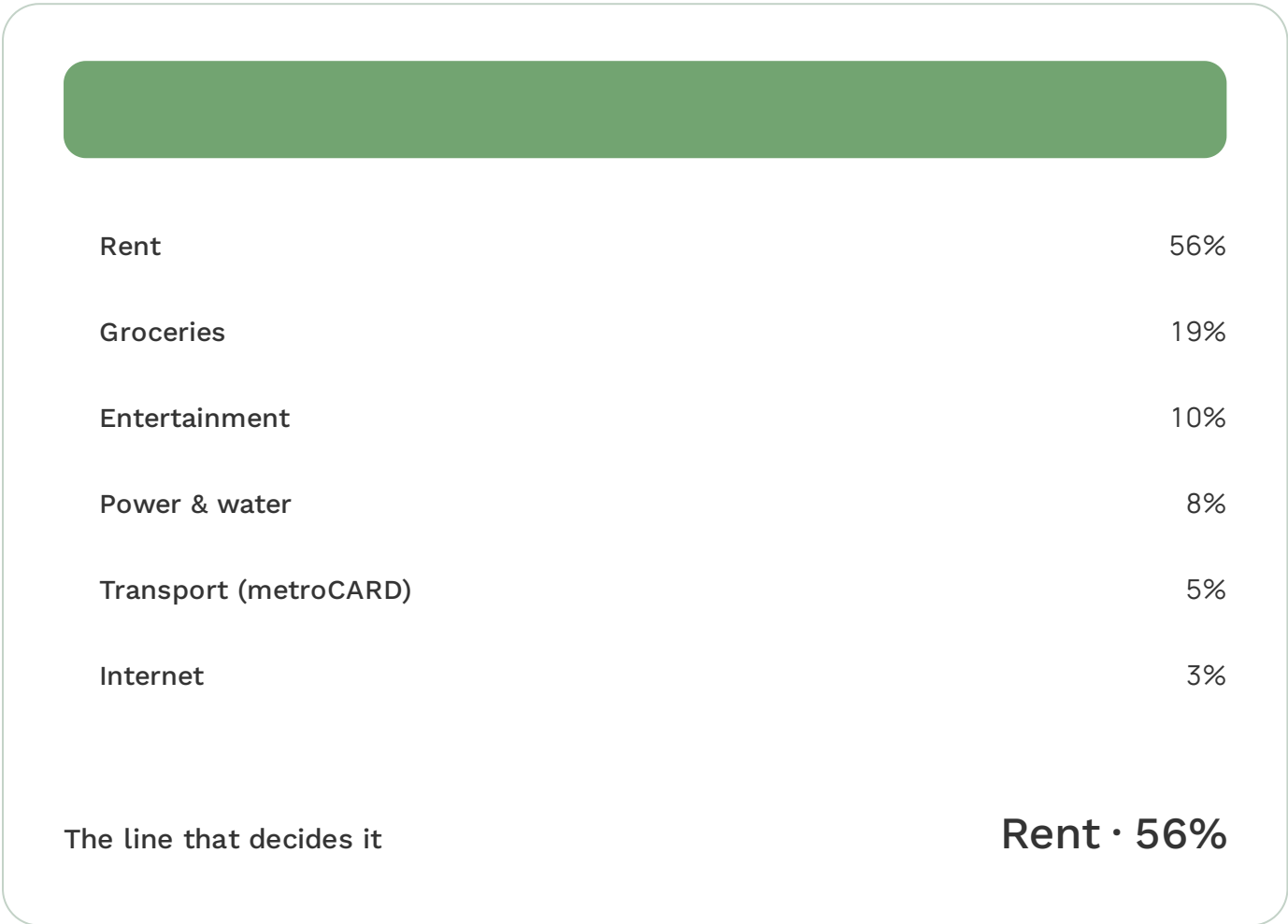
The headline

What doesn't change is the relationship: like-for-like housing runs hundreds of dollars a week below Sydney and well below Melbourne, and it is housing that decides whether a salary feels big.

What everyday life costs

THE MOST AFFORDABLE MAINLAND CAPITAL

The proportions, for one person on a mid-range budget. Proportions move slowly; prices move every quarter. Rent is fifty-six per cent of the month – the smallest rent line of any mainland capital.



The transport line is the smallest of any capital – no tolls, cheap parking by capital standards, and commutes short enough to save childcare hours. The honest picture here is a happy one; the chapter below prices the three costs the sunshine hides anyway.

The costs the sunshine hides

Power

South Australian electricity is among the dearest in the country, and summer cooling is non-negotiable. An efficient home and a deliberately chosen energy plan are worth real money a year – compare retailers before you sign anything.

The car you'll probably own

Inner-ring and tram-corridor life can be car-free; most Adelaide lives aren't. Price a reliable used car, registration and insurance into your arrival budget rather than discovering it in month two.

Flights east

If your people are in Sydney, Melbourne or overseas via the east, visits are fares, not drives. Two or three trips a year is the realistic line most families settle on — budget it.

Where the money comes back

The rent gap against the eastern capitals is the big one — for many households it covers the whole grocery bill. The small ones accumulate: no tolls, cheap parking by capital standards, commutes short enough to save childcare hours, the Central Market beating supermarket prices on produce, and the 10-cent container deposit quietly funding the coffee habit.

On the income side, public-health and not-for-profit roles here can salary-package part of your pay before tax — in a lower-cost city the effect on real quality of life is significant, and many international staff don't set it up until far too late. How packaging, tax and superannuation work is national and lives in **Pay & conditions**; the Adelaide habit to copy is simply asking payroll about it on day one.

The bottom line

Plan the bridge, not just the destination: temporary accommodation, a bond of up to four weeks' rent plus up to two weeks in advance, a first car, and setting up a home. In Adelaide that bridge costs far less than in the eastern capitals — but the people who arrive calm are the ones who priced it anyway.

Get today's numbers, and compare them to home

These are live and updated continuously, which is why we send you to them rather than competing with them. Put the city you are leaving in the other box.

Numbeo cost-of-living calculator (<https://www.numbeo.com/cost-of-living/>) — the most complete comparison tool, and the one most clinicians already use. Crowd-sourced, so read it as a ballpark rather than a quote.

Expatistan (<https://www.expatistan.com/cost-of-living>) — the same idea with a cleaner side-by-side. Worth running as a sanity check when Numbeo looks off.

Australian Bureau of Statistics (<https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation>) — official, slower, and the one to trust on the direction of travel rather than any single price.

If what you find contradicts the judgement on this page, tell us. We would rather correct the page than defend it.

Food, wine & the everyday

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Adelaide's everyday food culture runs through one building: the Central Market, trading since 1869 in the middle of the city grid. Around it sit the fiercely local supermarket, the surviving corner deli, and — because this is Adelaide — the assumption that decent wine is a grocery, not a luxury.

The Market and the weekly shop

The Adelaide Central Market is one of the best fresh-food markets in the country — seventy-odd stalls of produce, cheese, seafood, bread and world cuisines under one roof, cheaper and better than the supermarkets for most of what matters. Hospital staff treat Thursday evening or early Saturday as the serious shopping windows; go late Saturday afternoon for the closing-time bargains.

For the rest: Woolworths and Coles run full-range stores everywhere, ALDI is the cheapest weekly shop, and the local pride is real — Drakes and Foodland are South Australian institutions. The corner deli — part milk bar, part grocer, part sandwich counter — survives in Adelaide as it does nowhere else in the country.

Bring your bags

South Australia was the first state to ban lightweight plastic bags, and the checkout assumes you came prepared.

Save your bottles

The 10-cent container deposit has run since 1977. A crate in the boot and a monthly depot run is a genuine local rhythm.

Farmers' markets

Willunga on Saturday morning is the flagship; the Hills and the Barossa keep their own, all inside an hour.

The fritz order

At the deli counter, fritz and sauce on white bread is the childhood taste of the state. Order it once, for citizenship.

Flavours of home

For its size, Adelaide feeds its communities well. The western suburbs carry the Italian and Greek heritage – delis, continental grocers, the long Sunday lunch; the north and north-east are the centre of gravity for Asian, African and Middle-Eastern groceries; halal butchers are easy to find across the northern suburbs; and kosher supplies, while more limited than Sydney or Melbourne, are available through the long-established community in the east. The Market fills most gaps in one visit.

For newcomers this matters beyond ingredients: those shops sit alongside the associations, places of worship and weekend gatherings that make a new city feel liveable within a month rather than a year.

Eating and drinking out

Adelaide eats above its weight. The laneway small-bar scene – Peel Street, Leigh Street and their neighbours – arrived a decade ago and stayed; the pub is still the default meeting place; and the cellar doors of McLaren Vale, the Hills and the Barossa double as the city's best long lunches, forty minutes to an hour from town. Coffee is taken seriously without Melbourne's theology about it.

The heritage list is cheerfully odd: the pie floater – a meat pie upturned in pea soup – is the late-night institution, fritz is the deli order, and every March the whole food city moves outdoors into the festival gardens. Eating out costs noticeably less than Sydney; the wine list is where Adelaide quietly shows off.

The everyday, in one list

Serious shop: Central Market Thursday evening or Saturday morning; supermarkets for the rest.

Cheapest basket: ALDI; local loyalty: Drakes and Foodland; Saturday: Willunga farmers' market.

Specialist ingredients: west for Italian and Greek, north and north-east for Asian, African, Middle-Eastern and halal.

Bags in the car, bottles in a crate, fritz at least once.

Hills, coast & wine country

Adelaide Guide · Chapter 9 of 9

The recruiting pitch for Adelaide is really a geography lesson: almost everything worth a weekend sits within an hour of the city. This chapter is what people actually do with that — and the festival month the whole year bends around.

The wine hours

Four of the world's best-known wine regions ring the capital. The Barossa and the Adelaide Hills are inside an hour; McLaren Vale is forty minutes down the coast, where the vines run almost to the sea; the Clare Valley sits within two, its old railway now the Riesling Trail for a day's cycling between cellar doors. The practical effect: a long cellar-door lunch is a normal Saturday, not an anniversary. Vintage, in autumn, is the prettiest time to live here.

The coast

The city's own thirty kilometres of beach handle the everyday — jetty swims, esplanade runs, gulf sunsets that make the local news. Weekends stretch to the Fleurieu Peninsula's surf and coves, to Victor Harbor and the whale-watching season, and to Kangaroo Island — a ferry or a short flight — for wildlife, wilderness beaches and remarkable food.

Maslin Beach, where the metro coast gives way to the Fleurieu

The Hills

Twenty minutes up the freeway the air cools and the country turns green: Mount Lofty's summit and botanic garden, the Heysen Trail running through the ranges, Hahndorf's German heritage main street, and a run of villages that do log fires in winter and long lunches all year. It is the closest thing an Australian capital has to a countryside on its doorstep.

THREE DIRECTIONS, ALL UNDER TWO HOURS

The recruiting pitch for Adelaide is really a geography lesson, and this is it: three roads out of the city, and almost everything worth a weekend on one of them.

Up into the Hills

Twenty minutes up the freeway the air cools and the country turns green — log fires in winter, long lunches all year.

The city Stirling · 20 min Hahndorf Mount Barker · 35 min

Down the coast

Thirty kilometres of metropolitan beach first, then the vines running almost to the sea, then whale season.

The city Henley & Brighton · 20 min McLaren Vale · 40 min Victor Harbor

North to the valleys

Two of the world's best-known wine regions, and an old railway line now ridden between cellar doors.

The city The Barossa · ~1 hr Clare Valley · ~2 hr

Kangaroo Island is the exception — a ferry or a short flight rather than a drive. Everything else on this page is inside two hours, which is why a long cellar-door lunch here is a normal Saturday rather than an anniversary.

The festival year

Mad March

The Fringe — the southern hemisphere's biggest arts festival — plus the Adelaide Festival, WOMAdelaide and the motorsport, all at once. The city doubles in energy for a month.

Winter

Illuminate lights up the city in July; the Hills do log fires and galleries; the footy fills the oval — and the Showdown derby splits every workplace in two.

Spring & vintage

Tasting Australia in autumn, jacarandas and show season in spring, and harvest turning the valleys gold.

Ten weekends, to start

Barossa cellar doors and a bakery crawl through Tanunda and Angaston

McLaren Vale long lunch, then the coast road home via Sellicks

The Riesling Trail by bike through the Clare Valley

Kangaroo Island – Remarkable Rocks, sea lions and the island's produce

Mount Lofty summit at sunset, then the botanic garden below it

Hahndorf and the Hills villages, fog and all

Victor Harbor and the Fleurieu in whale season

The Willunga farmers' market, then the Vale for the afternoon

A jetty swim at Henley, then fish and chips on the esplanade

Mad March: one Fringe show, one Festival night, one WOMADelaide afternoon

That's the guide

Nine chapters on Adelaide. The rest of the state – the Riverland, the Eyre Peninsula, the South-East and the country networks – lives in the [South Australia guide](#), and everything national in [Moving to Australia](#). When you're ready to talk about real roles here, [we're easy to reach](#) – and there's no pipeline waiting on the other end of the call.